William Yu
HIST 0522O

The Romance of Chance: Exploring Gambling's Prevalence During the French and British Enlightenments

In its simplest form, to gamble is to wager on the outcome of a future event. While gambling has existed for centuries, the practice blossomed in 17th-century Europe with the birth of the first gambling houses, wherein organized, corporate-like structures resembling modern casinos were instituted. Within these coffee houses, bars, and private rooms, people of all classes, occupations, genders, and backgrounds gathered to wager their salaries, savings, and even fortunes. Through the economic, philosophical, and societal developments of the Enlightenment, gambling emerged at the forefront of the applications of these advancements. The lottery, stocks, and increasing flow of money – pillars of the developing capitalist system – were all rooted in gambling under the guise of investing in the nation. The Enlightenment's inquiry into reason, logic, and probability spurred an addiction to gambling on future outcomes. This new quantitative framework for understanding human experience reached its apex at the monetary opportunities that emerged at the gaming tables. Individually, the implications of one's profit, often at the expense of someone else's, came to be heavily critiqued for its immoral nature. Gambling during the Enlightenment embodied an imperfection in humanity's development of modern societal structures during the 17th and 18th centuries for the working classes. This essay focuses on Britain and France, where gambling became prevalent alongside each nation's groundbreaking economic advancements, forcing us to contend with the byproducts of such national developments on individuals. The vice of gambling complicates how we interpret the Enlightenment's impact, as it asserts a degeneracy of human nature persistent in the face of progress.

In the 17th century, gambling came to be directly rooted in the developing financial systems of Britain and France. Notably, in 1720, the South Sea Company proposed a groundbreaking transaction to relieve Britain's financial burden: it would take on the debt and exchange it for shares in the South Sea Company. Thomas Levenson noted the importance of this stock, as it was a "democratization of who could play in the financial markets."[1] Men, women, the wealthy, the poor, Quakers, atheists, and more engaged in the same activity and lost money. This bubble was not fundamentally fueled by individuals' desires to support their country's financial onus, but rather the chance of the stock increasing in value. Masked by the reasoning of supporting their nation's debt, the masses flocked to the gamble of the stock market. In questioning the pervading desire to gamble in a capitalist system more equitable than ever before, the shift toward interpreting reality through a mathematical lens, led by Isaac Newton, explains the change in one's relation to chance. The proliferation of mathematics applied measurement and analysis to the previously qualitative concepts of nature and life. Levenson notes how math was used to "model experience,"[2] citing Edmond Halley as a prime example. In 1693, given a list of births and deaths in a German town, he developed one of the first quantitative analyses, pricing life insurance. This concept of assigning a quantitative value to life and the future was a radical advancement in our understanding of the human condition. Nevertheless, its basis in chance came to devolve this mathematical understanding to directly oppose reason, as the allure of probability, formalized in monetary value, resulted in immense appeal in gambling. Thus the Enlightenment's contribution to pricing human experiences, underlined by a logical, quantitative framework, fostered the development of the institution of gambling, underwritten by values of probability, chance, and unfavorable odds.

---

[1] Peter Moore and Thomas Levenson, Money for Nothing in the South Sea Bubble: Thomas Levenson (1720), *Travels Through Time*, August 25, 2020.
[2] Moore and Levenson, South Sea Bubble, *Travels Through Time*, 2020.

From the opening of the first modern gambling house in Venice in 1638, gambling grew exponentially both in popularity and organization, developing into a dominant aspect of public life in Europe. Colburn's *New Monthly Magazine*, a British publication, detailed how methodical these operations had become by 1855, noting a minimum of 12 employees overseeing a house with duties such as commissioner, clerk, attorney, croupiers, waiter, and security.[3] Much like how the stock market appealed to the vast spectrum of the population, men and women of all social and economic classes participated in gambling houses betting on dice, card games, table games like roulette, and proposition bets. Notably though, the highly religious and those concerned with social values such as the moralists were vehemently opposed to gambling. Richard Hey's *A Dissertation on the Pernicious Effects of Gaming*, published in 1783, exemplified concerns with the moral underpinnings of gambling. Hey believed that we should "not be surprised"[4] at a gambler's "corruption of morals"[5] if they had "hitherto lived irreproachably"[6] and "fallen under the baneful influence of the Dice."[7] Moralists cited a "natural principle of sociability"[8] in their opposition to gambling, asserting that a gambler was "fundamentally, an unsocial man."[9] This dichotomy came to define the conflict over gambling's popularity, as while opposers referenced the act's nonconformity with the Enlightenment's constructions of reason, logic, and social values, gambling itself was so popular due to these developments.

---

[3] "GAMBLING IN THE EIGHTEENTH CENTURY," *The Eclectic Magazine of Foreign Literature (1844-1898),* 05, 1855, 13, https://www.proquest.com/magazines/gambling-eighteenth-century/docview/89731846/se-2.
[4] Richard Hey, "Three Dissertations on the Pernicious Effects of Gaming, on Duelling, and on Suicide: First Published in 1783, 1784, 1785, by Appointment ; as Having Gained, in the University of Cambridge, the Three Prizes of an Anonymous Donor" (dissertation, Cambridge, 1783).
[5] Hey, Dissertation, 1783.
[6] Hey, Dissertation, 1783.
[7] Hey, Dissertation, 1783.
[8] Justine Crump, The perils of play: Eighteenth-century ideas about gambling, 2004, https://www.histecon.magd.cam.ac.uk/docs/crump_perils.pdf.
[9] Crump, "The perils of play," 2004.

During the British and French Enlightenments, modern capitalism, business, and economy were being constructed, yet many were drawn to the allure of chance over a developing system more equitable than ever before. Jessica Richard described this problem as the "persistence of gambling in capitalism."[10] Writing that it "indicates an economy that is built not on rational calculation but on romance,"[11] gambling contradicted the emphasis on empirical evidence and logic being used to outline the nature of reality during this period. Hey alluded to the capitalist, traditional path to "gradual success,"[12] arguing that "with the idea of being one's self the prudent and industrious cause of it, will inspire the mind with vigor and spirits, far above all that can be expected from a few favorable strokes of mere Chance."[13] Nevertheless, gamblers "engag[ed] with the world that we can call romance,"[14] wherein "with rhythms of repetitions that promise control, celebrat[ed] the chance incalculable event, the heroic achievement against all odds, the lucky break, the unpredictable outcome."[15] The allure and "romance" of chance brought devastating harm to individuals who found themselves on the wrong side of the odds, leading to frequent suicides after losing all of their assets. Hey spent the last chapter of his dissertation lamenting the correlation between gambling and suicide, demonstrating the extent to which gambling had a hold on the working class. This presents a complicated and more nuanced view of the British and French Enlightenments, as even in groundbreaking economic developments, the middle and lower classes' struggle with gambling forces us to contend with the cost at which society truly advanced. The persistence of gambling existed in response to the

[10] Jessica Richard, "Putting to Hazard a Certainty": Lotteries and the Romance of Gambling in Eighteenth-Century England, *Studies in Eighteenth-Century Culture* 40 (2011): 179-200, doi:10.1353/sec.2011.0003.
[11] Richard, "Putting to Hazard a Certainty," 2011.
[12] Hey, Dissertation, 1783.
[13] Hey, Dissertation, 1783.
[14] Hey, Dissertation, 1783.
[15] Hey, Dissertation, 1783.

imperfections of the present societal structure as it became the most appealing outlet for working people to nullify their present state.

For the common person, the romance of gambling derived from its ability to remove one from the social hierarchy that still plagued 17th-century nations. Thus, as much as the expansion of empirical knowledge and reason populated much of the literature during this time, gambling was a popular yet stark regress from such ideals in its unreasonable accordance with losing probabilities. According to Justine Crump, gambling "threatened to subvert the ascendancy of the ruling class, as it became "contingent upon their possession of wealth."[16] The act of gambling risked one's "wealth, and, tacitly, their rank, in play."[17] However, many were willing and even eager to take this risk. Hey recognized the lifechanging opportunity that came with success, as the gambler "doubles indeed an ample fortune,"[18] but he warned that one otherwise "sinks to what a man of such fortune may, without much rhetorical figure, call Nothing."[19] This illogical, destructive activity deviated from reason, a core tenet of the Enlightenment, as it cast a materialistic lens upon the masses desperate to ascend the hierarchy. Gambling's persistence amongst the working class asserts that the Enlightenment was not tailored for them but rather for the wealthy and noble classes, as the prevailing sentiment was that chance was more appealing than the developing economic system. Instead of working towards "gradual success" like what Hey believed was the key to a worthwhile life, the masses determined that leaving their immediate future up to a losing probability was more favorable.

The development of a quantitative understanding of human experiences, led by Newton, had a profound effect on the individual's relation to their future, which was exemplified by

[16] Crump, "The perils of play," 2004.
[17] Crump, "The perils of play," 2004.
[18] Hey, Dissertation, 1783.
[19] Hey, Dissertation, 1783.

gambling. Jay Caplan asserted that "the calculus of probabilities implied a redefinition of the individual (person or event) as a statistical abstraction."[20] Within the context of gambling, this meant that one's future was determined by probabilistic chance. This starkly contrasted with many grounding arguments on the role of the individual and society cultivated during this period, yet many turned to gambling for this very reason. For a society that placed them in the lower classes, "probability theory offered the paradise of a purely present rationality,"[21] removed from the "burdens of history, family, and class."[22] Newton was fundamental in developing this quantitative lens through which society was viewed. According to Levenson, "He's the absolute captain of the revolution that's changing how we use math to understand what we do in life."[23] Gambling used math to quantify the human experience in such a way that many preferred over the prevailing societal structure. Gambling was so persistent even through its destructive effects due to its allure, which Robert Fajen described as an "alternative order."[24] In his view, gambling was "inextricably linked to the risk of seeing things radically differently and of thinking the world anew."[25] The addicting appeal of gambling speaks to the shortcomings of the British and French Enlightenments, as illogical, destructive table games of chance persisted in a time of supposed societal advancement. The concepts of progress in every field, expansion of business, trade, and knowledge, and adherence to reason that uplifted the Enlightenment's lasting impact were devoid in these gambling houses where many lost their savings and thus, their lives. This

[20] Jay Caplan, *SubStance* 24, no. 3 (1995): 132–35, https://doi.org/10.2307/3685015.
[21] Caplan, *SubStance* 24, 1995.
[22] Caplan, *SubStance* 24, 1995.
[23] Moore and Levenson, South Sea Bubble, *Travels Through Time*, 2020.
[24] Robert Fajen, "Amusement and Risk: Enlightenment as a Game in the French and Italian 18th Century," Interdisciplinary Centre for European Enlightenment Studies, 2019, https://www.izea.uni-halle.de/en/research/b-structures-of-knowledge/4-forms-of-representation-and-epistemic-models/amusement-and-risk-enlightenment-as-a-game-in-the-french-and-italian-18th-century.html.
[25] Fajen, "Amusement and Risk," 2019.

stark reality was only further propagated by the wealthy's relation to gambling, developing a striking juxtaposition of class fueled by a new, rigid quantitative determination of societal rank.

For the wealthy, gambling served a completely different purpose compared to the lower classes, acting as a public method of asserting one's status through the quantitative lens that everyone understood: money. According to Thomas Kavanagh, gambling instilled a palpable "contempt for the anonymous power of money"[26] for the wealthy, who used it as a "token of class affiliation."[27] In his view, they used gambling as an "affirmation"[28] of their "superiority to any change of fortune consisting solely in a gain or loss of money."[29] King Charles II was an archetype of this concept, as he "demonstrate[d] his right to his throne, the acme of the hierarchy, by ritually sitting down to lose"[30] money. Richard asserts that gambling was an integral aspect of the wealthy's sense of self, as "not only can they afford to gamble, but their gambling defines them."[31] More broadly, wealth came to order the social stratification more publicly than ever through these public displays of fortunes won and lost in games. While the middle and lower classes staked their status on chance, the wealthy demonstrated their ability to play the same games and risk nothing. Gambling only served to further the wealth gap between the already wealthy and working people, as mathematically, one was predetermined to lose money when playing a game an arbitrary number of times. Thus, Donna Andrew noted the criticisms being made of a "different type of gambling"[32] that existed "in Society, in the world of the great, the leisured, and the beautiful,"[33] asserting the "harm to individuals, to society, and to the economic

[26] Caplan, *SubStance* 24, 1995.
[27] Caplan, *SubStance* 24, 1995.
[28] Caplan, *SubStance* 24, 1995.
[29] Caplan, *SubStance* 24, 1995.
[30] Caplan, *SubStance* 24, 1995.
[31] Richard, "Putting to Hazard a Certainty," 2011.
[32] Donna Andrew, *Aristocratic Vice: The Attack on Duelling, Suicide, Adultery, and Gambling in Eighteenth-Century England*, New Haven: Yale University Press, 2013.
[33] Andrew, "Aristocratic Vice," 2013.

as well as political life of the nation."[34] Gambling's impact on socioeconomic classes seemed to counteract what the British and French Enlightenments were working towards in terms of economic progress in developing the roots of modern capitalism, yet gambling became so popular because of the Enlightenment concept of quantitative reasoning. Analyzing gambling's prevalence in Europe during the 17th and 18th centuries provides a more comprehensive image of what "progress" meant in terms of the Enlightenment's impact. The turbulent inner-societal dynamics that arose due to gambling asserted that nation-building advancements came at the expense of the nation's community itself, as the publicization of status only served to divide.

Hey, moralists, and those concerned with social values were staunchly opposed to gambling based on its detrimental impact on virtually every aspect of society, both individual and communal. Hey viewed gamblers as "abandoning all true principles of Virtue and Benevolence, and in consequence bringing Distress and Misery"[35] to those around them. Furthering this notion of human nature, he saw gambling as an "artificial appetite"[36] that absorbed "the natural inclinations and perceptions which were meant to lead"[37] one to their "earthly happiness."[38] In Hey's opinion, natural, earthly happiness consisted of family, sex, love, and community, all of which were put at risk in a gambling addiction. Moralists echoed Hey's sentiments, fearing the destruction of the "domestic realm"[39] and fervently denouncing its implication on the individual's relation to others. Hey's interpretation of gambling's influence on one's demeanor was strikingly melancholy as he lamented how "in the circle of mutual Foes who surround the board,"[40] "the mind of every man is sharpened against his neighbor."[41] Devoid of

[34] Andrew, "Aristocratic Vice," 2013.
[35] Hey, Dissertation, 1783.
[36] Hey, Dissertation, 1783.
[37] Hey, Dissertation, 1783.
[38] Hey, Dissertation, 1783.
[39] Crump, "The perils of play," 2004.
[40] Hey, Dissertation, 1783.
[41] Hey, Dissertation, 1783.

compassion, Hey saw "selfishness shocking to humanity,"[42] as one "rejoice[d] in the misfortunes of those whom Benevolence and a friendly Intercourse would have instructed him to commiserate and relieve."[43] It is revelatory to see the detrimental impact that the British and French Enlightenments had on these values, as it is counterintuitive to correlate this period with the degradation of communal life. Moreover, as gambling's roots lie in these nations' Enlightenments, we witness the propagation of its vices into the population.

As the vices associated with gambling furthered their reach into the public, critics feared the degradation of social order, thus vehemently warning of its impending devastation. Hey believed that "all considerations are taught to give way to self-interest"[44] in gambling, meaning that they "contravened a natural principle of sociability."[45] A gambler was thus "an unsocial man."[46] He alluded to crucial concepts developed during the Enlightenment such as human nature and reason, asserting that play should be avoided for it "is repugnant to our very Nature."[47] In an issue of *The Times*, "the vice of gaming"[48] was correlated to inevitable "suicide, adultery, bankruptcy, and the gallows."[49] Moralists were concerned with the virtues that grounded their societies, but more broadly, they opposed the nature of probability in human life. They sought to "banish the uncertainties – moral, economic, social, and political,"[50] so that they could maintain the "social order across the eighteenth century."[51] Through this lens, gambling seemingly appeared to be a self-inflicted infection brought on by the British and French Enlightenments. In an effort to form the basis of modern capitalism, rational understanding, and

[42] Hey, Dissertation, 1783.
[43] Hey, Dissertation, 1783.
[44] Hey, Dissertation, 1783.
[45] Hey, Dissertation, 1783.
[46] Hey, Dissertation, 1783.
[47] Hey, Dissertation, 1783.
[48] "GAMBLING IN THE EIGHTEENTH CENTURY," *The Eclectic Magazine of Foreign Literature,* 1855.
[49] "GAMBLING IN THE EIGHTEENTH CENTURY," *The Eclectic Magazine of Foreign Literature,* 1855.
[50] Crump, "The perils of play," 2004.
[51] Crump, "The perils of play," 2004.

quantitative thinking, gambling preyed upon the more rigid, monetary social stratification. Money had never had a greater impact, both perceived and actual, giving way to a pervading addiction to the chance of making more, even with unfavorable odds.

The romance of chance emerged at the forefront of British and French society through the development of quantitatively understanding human experience, a trademark aspect of these nations' Enlightenments during the 17th and 18th centuries. Gambling, in stocks, lotteries, and table, dice, and card games minimized the playing field to one's willingness to bet on a future outcome, yet this only further diverged socioeconomic classes. Romance taking precedence over rational calculation spoke to the Enlightenment's troubling impact on the middle and lower classes, as vices of envy and selfishness seethed through an addiction to the games. A superficial view of the literature and discourse throughout these centuries isolates its impact on the noble, intellectual, and wealthy classes. However, gambling opened the advancements of this period to everyone, exposing the complicated shortcomings of pushing development on a national scale. The gaping division of classes, families, and individuals that formed from a monetary determination of life was a regression in human society, one invoked by the Enlightenment movement.

Bibliography

Andrew, Donna T. *Aristocratic Vice: The Attack on Duelling, Suicide, Adultery, and Gambling in Eighteenth-Century England*. New Haven: Yale University Press, 2013.

Caplan, Jay L. *SubStance* 24, no. 3 (1995): 132–35. https://doi.org/10.2307/3685015.

Crump, Justine. The perils of play: Eighteenth-century ideas about gambling, 2004. https://www.histecon.magd.cam.ac.uk/docs/crump_perils.pdf.

Fajen, Robert. "Amusement and Risk: Enlightenment as a Game in the French and Italian 18th Century." Interdisciplinary Centre for European Enlightenment Studies, 2019. https://www.izea.uni-halle.de/en/research/b-structures-of-knowledge/4-forms-of-represen

tation-and-epistemic-models/amusement-and-risk-enlightenment-as-a-game-in-the-french-and-italian-18th-century.html.

"GAMBLING IN THE EIGHTEENTH CENTURY." *The Eclectic Magazine of Foreign Literature (1844-1898)*. 05, 1855, 13. https://www.proquest.com/magazines/gambling-eighteenth-century/docview/89731846/se-2.

Hey, Richard. "Three Dissertations on the Pernicious Effects of Gaming, on Duelling, and on Suicide: First Published in 1783, 1784, 1785, by Appointment ; as Having Gained, in the University of Cambridge, the Three Prizes of an Anonymous Donor." Dissertation, Cambridge, 1783.

Moore, Peter, and Thomas Levenson. Money for Nothing in the South Sea Bubble: Thomas Levenson (1720). *Travels Through Time*, August 25, 2020.

Richard, Jessica. "Putting to Hazard a Certainty": Lotteries and the Romance of Gambling in Eighteenth-Century England. *Studies in Eighteenth-Century Culture* 40 (2011): 179-200. doi:10.1353/sec.2011.0003.